Seeking Ideas to Fund CivicChat: A Transformative Tech Project for the Public Good

My name is Ken Granderson, and I'm looking to develop **CivicChat**, an initiative designed to serve the public good. The goal of this document is to introduce CivicChat, share its vision and potential impact, and explore opportunities for securing funding to bring it to life.

As a Black technologist with over 30 years of experience developing advanced software for underserved communities, I've dedicated my career to using technology to empower people (Google my name for details). **CivicChat** is my latest public interest project, and it's something I believe has the potential to transform civic engagement in the United States. However, like many projects intended for the public good, I cannot personally finance it and am seeking funding opportunities in the range of **$250,000 to $500,000** to develop and launch CivicChat. I'm circulating this information in the hopes that you might have ideas on how we could secure appropriate funding.

What is CivicChat?

CivicChat is a mobile-first platform that leverages cutting-edge technologies like **generative artificial intelligence**, **speech recognition**, **real-time translation**, and **mobile technology** to make it easier for Americans to learn how their government works—from the local to the national level. Our goal is to help inspire more citizens to get involved in their government because they understand it better, by helping them stay informed about the roles, responsibilities and positions their elected officials and candidates hold, including:

- **Voting records** of elected officials
- **Policy stances** on key issues
- **Comparisons** of elected officials' positions to those of the citizen

By offering these insights in real time, CivicChat seeks to empower users to make informed decisions about the political landscape. Importantly, CivicChat is **nonpartisan** and **transparent** about where we gather our information from, including sharing metadata about the known political leanings of information sources.

Transparency and Trust

CivicChat is built on the principles of **transparency** and trust. We don't make specific recommendations to voters; instead, we provide the information, highlight potential biases from sources, and leave it up to the citizen to make their own informed decisions. Our goal is to make this a **freely accessible platform** for all Americans. We believe that informed citizens are crucial to a thriving democracy, and our technology can help make political education more accessible to all.

Open-Source Vision

Once CivicChat is built, we plan to make it **open source**, so that others can extend the platform in ways that we may not anticipate or prioritize in the initial release. For example, this could include enhancing accessibility features for citizens with disabilities or adding new data sets that provide deeper political

insights. CivicChat's potential for growth and impact is immense, and we believe that opening it up to the community will ensure it continues to serve the public good in innovative ways.

A Unique Opportunity for HBCU Students

As an independent Black technologist, I want to build CivicChat in partnership with students from **Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs)** and will be reaching out to educators and administrators at **Medgar Evers College** in Brooklyn, where I reside, and **Morgan State University**, who I have seen come across my radar several times in regard to showing forward thinking in regard to technology.

A foundational aspect of my philosophy about Technology is that, based on my personal lived experiences, I believe that mastering Technology for OUR benefit is the single most leverageable and practical route for Black Empowerment, because:

1. Technology controls, enables or influences almost EVERYTHING in industrialized societies, and unlike in the world of humans, where more than a few possess the unfortunate combination of economic or other forms of power over you, along with a racist mindset,

2. Technology works the same, no matter who runs it, so…

3. If you want to run the Industrialized World, learn to run Technology.

To me, it's that simple. 1 + 2 = 3.

From MY vantage point, as I have been ringing the bell since 1995 that WE need to be about using Technology for OUR people (https://links.blackfacts.com/350years), we are almost 30 years behind in leveraging CURRENT, CUTTING EDGE Technology, and since I still don't see anyone else doing it, I guess I'll do it myself and offer HBCU students hands-on experience working on a meaningful social-impact Tech project that can introduce the nation and the world to the idea of cutting-edge software being developed by Black people, and give the students direct, hands-on experience with technologies like:

- Multi-language conversational interfaces leveraging AI and speech recognition
- Generative Artificial Intelligence for providing personalized, data-driven insights
- Creating REST APIs to support interaction with external systems
- AI RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) Pipelines to power advanced AI functionality
- Web scraping and data gathering from various sources
- Relational database management to support a dynamic civic engagement tool
- Learning Scrum-Based Development to manage agile project workflows
- Test-Driven Development (TDD) to ensure quality and reliability in the software
- CI/CD DevOps for continuous integration, delivery, and deployment of code
- And more

I personally do ALL these now for various parts of my BlackFacts ecosystem and client projects.

The Modules of CivicChat

While I won't get too technical in this overview (tech details available upon request), CivicChat will include several key modules that work together to deliver its core functionality. These modules will:

- **Identify elected officials** based on a user's location
- **Provide voting records** and key stances of politicians
- **Find and summarize news stories** and **public statements**
- **Compare candidates' positions** with those of the citizen
- Offer a **conversational interface** to make the user experience as simple and intuitive as possible
- Deliver this experience in the citizen's **native language** to remove language as a barrier from understanding

These modules will be designed to ensure that CivicChat delivers accurate, timely, and unbiased information, empowering users to stay informed and engaged in the political process.

The CivicChat Proof Of Concept

CivicChat has a Proof Of Concept online demo version that lets you learn basic information about local to state-level New York officials in a variety of languages.

The POC Demo is at https://civicchat.nyc

YMMV WARNING: The current demo relies on languages installed on your computer or device and will not be that useful on most mobile phones. On Windows desktop, I have 5 different browsers installed and get the greatest number of languages in Microsoft Edge. Don't even think about it on my Android phone.

Regardless of how the online demo works (or not), this video shows you what it's like today on a machine that has about 100 languages installed.

The release version of CivicChat will use external translation services to provide consistent language support across all devices.

https://links.blackfacts.com/civic-chat



Who Am I?

I mentioned early that I've been at this for a while. This 3 ½ minute video covers my 30 years of being an Unapologetically Black Technologist, and touches on several of my major projects and most of my current activities.

https://links.blackfacts.com/about-ken



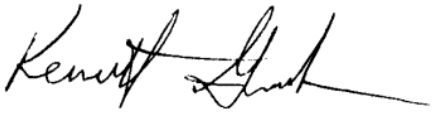
Call to Action: How Can We Fund CivicChat?

CivicChat is a project with massive potential to make a lasting impact on civic engagement, but I cannot fund this on my own. I'm seeking your advice and support to identify funding sources in the range of **$250,000 to $500,000** to bring CivicChat to life. Whether through government grants, philanthropic initiatives, or strategic partnerships, I believe there are paths to make this transformative project a reality. If you know of any SPECIFIC opportunities or individuals (not easily searched or commonly known) who support initiatives at the intersection of Technology and Civic Engagement, I would greatly appreciate your insight or assistance.

Thank you for taking the time to consider this project. I look forward to any suggestions or connections you may be able to offer. Together, we can make CivicChat a powerful tool for public good.

Talk soon.

Your Friendly Neighborhood Unapologetically Black Tech Visionary,



P.S. feel free to share this with anyone you think would be interested!

P.P.S. You can download or share a PDF copy of this document by clicking HERE.

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